

Psychology Lecture: Understanding Emotion

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lecture, students should be able to:

- Define what emotions are and differentiate them from mood and affect.
- Understand major psychological theories of emotion.
- Recognize the biological, cognitive, and social components of emotion.
- Apply emotional concepts to real-life and clinical contexts.

1. Introduction to Emotion

Definition: Emotion is a complex psychological state involving subjective experience, physiological response, and behavioral expression.

Components of Emotion:

- Subjective experience (e.g., happiness, anger)
- Physiological response (e.g., heart rate)
- Behavioral expression (e.g., facial expressions)

2. Theories of Emotion

James-Lange Theory: Emotions result from physiological arousal. ("We feel afraid because we tremble.")

Cannon-Bard Theory: Arousal and emotion occur simultaneously.

Schachter-Singer Theory: Emotion = Arousal + Cognitive Label.

Lazarus Theory: Cognitive appraisal comes before emotion.

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3. Biological Bases of Emotion

- Limbic System: Especially the amygdala and hippocampus
- Prefrontal cortex: Regulation and decision-making
- Autonomic Nervous System: Sympathetic vs. parasympathetic systems

4. Expression and Recognition of Emotion

- Paul Ekman's Basic Emotions: Happiness, sadness, fear, anger, surprise, disgust
- Cultural differences in display rules
- Emotion recognition and its role in social interaction

5. Emotion and Cognition

- Emotion affects attention, memory, and decision-making
- Emotional Intelligence (Daniel Goleman): Self-awareness, regulation, empathy

6. Emotion Regulation

Strategies: Reappraisal, suppression, mindfulness

Importance in mental health (e.g., depression, anxiety)

7. Clinical Perspectives

- Affective Disorders: Depression, bipolar disorder
- Alexithymia: Difficulty identifying emotions
- Emotional Dysregulation in Borderline Personality Disorder

8. Applied Contexts

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Emotion in:

- Education
- Marketing/Consumer behavior
- Healthcare and therapy
- Workplace psychology

Suggested Readings & Resources

- 'Emotion' by James W. Kalat
- 'The Emotional Brain' by Joseph LeDoux
- Paul Ekman's research on facial expressions
- APA Journal: 'Emotion'